

**Middle level (approx. salary per annum:
Rs 5 lakh to Rs 7 lakh)**

Network / System Administrator
Network Design Engineer
Network Systems Technician/Specialist
Network Engineer

**Top level (approx. salary per annum:
Rs 8.5 lakh to Rs 10+ lakh)**

Chief Technology Officer
VP - IT / Systems

Diploma holders can expect a start from as low as Rs 85,000 per annum.

After entering at the beginner level in technical support, it takes about two to three years for one to advance to the next level. At a middle level position such as a Network Engineer or Network / System Administrator, the variety of tasks and the work profile are as complex as the network itself! One acquires knowledge and experience of managing, maintaining, and providing solutions for the networks primarily at this level. Advancing from the middle level to the next level—as in from Network Engineer to Network Administrator—takes around five to seven years, and sometimes more than that. Finally, to get to a top-level position such as VP—IT or Systems, eight to 12 years or more of experience could be needed.

All these time periods are just indicative: it's the inner drive and interest in constant learning in an individual that takes him to the top.

The Roles At Each Level

After joining the networking department of an organisation, the roles as an individual advances from one level to another are different. Certain activities may overlap at the beginner and middle levels. Here is a snapshot of what kind of role is played at each level.

Service Technician / Technical Support

The first step and the entry-level position in networking. One is sent to customers' sites to perform field upgrades and support functions. One acts as a support to the Network Technician by physical installation of hardware and software, setting up switches, routers, cables, etc. The true test of one's basics and the training acquired is observed here.

Network Technicians

Network Technicians tend to focus on the setup, troubleshooting, and attending to the problems and repair of hardware and software products. They take care of the entire network within a company, and attend to the problems in the networks with the help of Service Technicians. This is the stage where one gets in touch with the practical aspects for application of their knowledge and basics of networking.

Network Engineer

The Network Engineer focuses on functions such as cabling of networks, installation of routers, switches, day-to-day operations, etc. Also, he takes care of system upgrades, evaluation of vendor products on networks, security tests of the network, and so forth.



“Boot camps and other training programs should teach one how to perform in the real world rather than how to pass tests and make them paper-tigers”

Arun Eapen
Technical Consultant
and Networking
Specialist
Red Hat India

Network Programmers And Analysts

Network Programmers write programs or scripts that help evaluate third-party network products and help in network analysis. They try to integrate new software technologies into an existing or new network environment. Analysts analyse and monitor traffic, the use of bandwidth, and data transfer over the network.

Network / System Administrators

They perform the tasks of configuring and managing LANs, WANs, and VPNs for an organisation. Providing access to the network from the remotest locations of the organisation is their responsibility. They have to provide security by configuring firewalls; good knowledge of security implementations, routing, TCP/IP, virus protection applications and spam filters is required of them. Their daily routine involves monitoring network performance, maintaining network security, and troubleshooting.

Network Information / Design Managers

They supervise the work of administrators, engineers, technicians and programmers. They also work on the long-term planning and strategy of an organisation's network. At the entry level, one would focus on tasks such as troubleshooting, monitoring, evaluation of LAN performance, adding and deleting users, adding new servers, and such.

The Opportunities

Network professionals will always be in demand—for as long as IT fuels the economy. Today, a shortage of network professionals is faced in sectors such as ITES / BPO, telecom, banking and financial services, manufacturing, and even government. Retail is an upcoming part of the Indian economy which will fuel the need for even more network professionals.

The demand for more than two lakh network professionals will go up within the next one year; only about 1.4 lakh Indian networking professionals are in existence today—the demand for network professionals is higher than supply. The BPO/ITES sector will witness the highest growth in demand for network professionals; also will other sectors such as Banking and Financial Services, Telecom and Retail.

Summing It Up

Job seekers are ever haunted by the word “experience”; “organisations only hire people with relevant experience” whenever they apply for jobs! One needs to take the initiative—by taking up full-time programming projects or help-desk internships in networking.

A good way to stand out is to demonstrate prior working experience by selecting projects or getting work experience in the area of your interest. This prior experience could serve as a launchpad, advancing you to the next level. Networking technology changes every few years, so organisations look for individuals who can adapt to upcoming technologies: this happens when there is a constant hunger for learning—in which case, the sky is the limit! ■

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